Hejira Nefertiti S. Macalandong-Limbona

Dr. Bai Hejira Nefertiti Sinsuat Macalandong-Limbona is the 4th elected Chancellor of Mindanao State University-Maguindanao (MSU-Maguindanao), one of the eight constituent universities of the Mindanao State University System in the southern Philippines.<ref name="biosketch">Template:Cite web</ref>

A daughter of the university's legacy, a practitioner of public administration, and a champion of women's rights in conflict-affected communities, Chancellor Limbona has spent her entire professional life building up a single institution, and in doing so, she has become one of the most consequential academic leaders the Bangsamoro region has produced in recent decades.

Her chancellorship has been defined by a clear conviction: that the university is not merely a place for degrees, but a vehicle for genuine peace and development in Mindanao.

She was among the first to push MSU-Maguindanao toward what would become its most globally recognized milestone, a pioneering academic program on Women, Peace and Security that earned recognition across Southeast Asia and drew partnerships with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), the British Government, and universities in Indonesia.<ref name="gov.uk">Template:Cite web</ref>

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Dr. Bai Hejira Nefertiti Sinsuat Macalandong-Limbona



Born	Cotabato City, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Education	B.S. Information and Computer Science (1999); B.S. Business Administration (2002); Master in Public Administration (2010); Ph.D. in Public Administration (2013)
Alma mater	St. Paul College of Manila; De La Salle-College of Saint Benilde; Asian Institute of Management; Mindanao State University-Maguindanao; Cotabato City State Polytechnic College; Development Academy of the Philippines
Occupation	University Chancellor, academic administrator, public servant
Title	Chancellor, MSU-Maguindanao (4th, elected)
Spouse	Hon. Asnawi S. Limbona
Children	4
Parents	Prof. Bai Yasmin Q. Sinsuat (mother); Prof. Nazarollah R. Macalandong (father)

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Background and Family

Dr. Limbona was born and raised in Cotabato City, the bustling urban center at the heart of the Bangsamoro region in central Mindanao.

Her family background is deeply intertwined with the history of MSU-Maguindanao itself.

She is the eldest daughter of **Prof. Bai Yasmin Q. Sinsuat**, a former Chancellor of MSU-Maguindanao, and **Prof. Nazarollah R. Macalandong**, who served as Vice President for Administration and Finance of the MSU System. <ref name="biosketch"/>

Growing up in a household where academic governance, public service, and Bangsamoro heritage were not just dinner-table topics but lived realities gave her a distinct vantage point that few of her peers could match.

The Sinsuat name itself carries weight in Maguindanao history, associated with civic leadership and institutional memory in a region that has long struggled to balance political turbulence with the aspiration for progress.

She is married to the Honorable Asnawi S. Limbona, and they are blessed with four children.

Education

Dr. Limbona's educational path reflects an unusually wide intellectual curiosity, moving from computing to business management to public leadership, and ultimately to the academic study of governance.

She began with a Bachelor of Science in Information and Computer Science from St. Paul College of Manila, completing the degree in 1999.<ref name="biosketch"/>

Three years later, in 2002, she earned a second bachelor's degree, a Bachelor of Science in Business Administration with a major in Computer Applications, from De La Salle-College of Saint Benilde in Manila.<ref name="biosketch"/>

That dual foundation in technology and business would prove prescient: decades later, she would be the one advocating for digital connectivity as a tool for integrating Muslim communities into the national mainstream.

In 2003, she completed the Building Leadership program at the Asian Institute of Management in Manila, a formative experience that sharpened her orientation toward institutional reform and organizational leadership.<ref name="biosketch"/>

She then turned her formal studies toward public governance.

In 2010, she finished her Master in Public Administration degree from MSU-Maguindanao, the very institution she would later lead.<ref name="biosketch"/>

In 2012, she completed the Administrative Excellence Service Executive Development Program for State Universities and Colleges (SUCs) through the Development Academy of the Philippines.<ref name="biosketch"/>

The following year, 2013, she earned her Doctor of Philosophy in Public Administration from Cotabato City State Polytechnic College, which also awarded her the Certificate of Academic Excellence in recognition of her scholarly performance.<ref name="biosketch"/>

Career at MSU-Maguindanao

Early Service and Administrative Roles

Chancellor Limbona's career at MSU-Maguindanao did not begin at the top. It began at the entry level, and she worked her way up methodically over more than a decade.

She was appointed as an instructor at the age of 23, barely out of her own undergraduate studies, stepping into a teaching role at the same university where her mother had served as chancellor.<ref name="biosketch"/>

It's worth pausing on that detail: walking into an institution your parent once led as a junior instructor takes a certain confidence, and it set the tone for her entire professional trajectory.

In 2003, she joined the Internal Audit System of MSU-Maguindanao, a role that placed her at the intersection of administrative accountability and institutional governance.<ref name="biosketch"/>

That same year, she became Managing Editor of the university's Newsletter Editorial Board, a post she held until 2007, helping shape institutional communication during a period of growth for the campus.<ref name="biosketch"/>

From 2004 to 2007, she served concurrently as Director of the Division of Student Affairs, a role that brought her directly into the lives of the student population, many of them coming from underserved communities across Maguindanao and neighboring provinces.<ref name="biosketch"/>

Vice Chancellor for Administration and Finance

From 2008 to 2014, Dr. Limbona served as Vice Chancellor for Administration and Finance, one of the most demanding executive positions in any university's organizational structure.<ref name="biosketch"/>

That six-year tenure gave her a thorough understanding of institutional finance, human resources, and operational management, the kind of ground-level fluency in how a university actually functions that chancellors who come in as pure academics often lack.

By the time she was elected chancellor, she had accumulated nine years of leadership and managerial experience across student affairs, editorial work, internal audit, and university-wide finance.

Election as Chancellor

Dr. Limbona was elected as the 4th Chancellor of MSU-Maguindanao, succeeding the line of chancellors who had built the institution from its agricultural college origins in 1973 into a full-service university serving the Bangsamoro region.<ref name="biosketch"/>

She was subsequently reappointed as chancellor, continuing in the role with the formal designation as the Fourth Regular Chancellor of the institution.<ref name="reappointed">Template:Cite web</ref>

Vision and Institutional Leadership

Chancellor Limbona has articulated a clear, consistent vision for MSU-Maguindanao: to make it globally recognized as a premiere innovative institution that provides excellent quality education, exceptional research advancement, and a diverse study environment.<ref name="biosketch"/>

What makes that vision more than just aspiration is the specificity with which she has pursued it through partnerships, programs, and policy advocacy.

She has consistently framed the university's mission in terms of its Bangsamoro context, insisting that an excellent university in Maguindanao is not just an academic project but a contribution to the peace process.

Her approach to governance blends a service ethic drawn from Islamic values with a practical administrator's attention to institutional mechanics.

In 2022, speaking after a meeting with Bangsamoro Chief Minister Ahod Ebrahim, she said:

> *"Our plan will be a milestone for MSU and will be a trademark for BARMM in developing the academe and to produce more excellent Bangsamoro professionals in the different courses offered by MSU in the future."*

During a 2025 stakeholders' meeting in Paglat, she was equally direct about what she expected students to gain from their time at the university:

> *"What we want is for our students to be provided with what they need so that when they finish college, they will pass the board exam or bar and, hopefully, the skills and competence they acquire at MSU-Maguindanao will be enough for them to secure a decent job in their chosen field."*

Contributions and Initiatives

Diploma in Women, Peace and Security

Perhaps the most historically significant achievement of Chancellor Limbona's tenure is her role in establishing the Diploma in Women, Peace and Security (DWPS), widely recognized as the first academic diploma of its kind in Southeast Asia.

Developed in partnership with the Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID), and supported by the European Union, the UNDP, and the British Embassy Manila, the diploma program is offered fully online across three semesters, making it accessible to students and practitioners who would otherwise be unable to attend traditional on-campus programs.<ref name="icwps"/>

Chancellor Limbona captured the program's ambition in precise terms when she said:

> *"DPWPS is not merely a diploma, it is a platform of praxis of WPS champions, practitioners and leaders, enabling the vision of WPS pillars and frameworks in institutions across all sectors, procedural systems and geopolitical borders."*

The program has drawn international attention.

In October 2024, a delegation led by Chancellor Limbona attended the International Conference on Women, Peace and Security (ICWPS) at the Philippine International Convention Center (PICC) in Manila, a landmark global event that convened 691 delegates from 84 countries, including 27 ministerial-level officials and parliamentarians. <ref name="icwps"/>

MSU-Maguindanao maintained a prominent presence at the event, showcasing the DWPS program as a model for academic institutions seeking to embed gender, peace, and security into their core offerings.

International Academic Partnerships

Under Chancellor Limbona's leadership, MSU-Maguindanao has built a series of meaningful international partnerships, particularly in the area of women, peace, and security.

In 2025, with support from the UK Government's Indo-Pacific Governance Fund and the UNDP, the university led an international learning exchange in Yogyakarta, Indonesia, which resulted in the signing of Memoranda of Understanding with three major Indonesian universities: Universitas Gadjah Mada, Universitas Muhammadiyah Yogyakarta, and Universitas Ahmad Dahlan.

These agreements aim to advance cooperation in gender education, research, and community engagement across Southeast Asia.

Chancellor Limbona described what the exchanges meant in practice:

> *"These learning exchanges spark the curiosity that drives meaningful research and action, exactly what we need to not only mainstream the WPS agenda, but to truly transform the challenging situations facing our women, communities and families."*

She also led MSU-Maguindanao's signing of scholarship Memoranda of Agreement with the European Union and the Magbassa Kita Foundation, Inc., expanding access to higher education for Bangsamoro students.

The university has also signed a MOA with Nueva Ecija University of Science and Technology (NEUST) for the joint offering of a Diploma in WPS with a specialization in Indigenous Peoples' Perspectives, further extending the reach of MSU-Maguindanao's flagship peace education program to other regions of the Philippines.

Peace Education and the UNDP Partnership

In a separate but related initiative, MSU-Maguindanao under Chancellor Limbona partnered with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) Philippines and the MSU Institute for Peace and Development in Mindanao (IPDM) to conduct a training workshop on the effective integration of peace into the university curriculum.

The initiative was part of MSU's transition toward becoming a National Peace University, a mandate rooted in the university's foundational legislation, Republic Act 1387, which charged it with advancing national unity through education.

The workshop involved college deans, directors of the Graduate School, heads of academic offices, program advisers, and faculty, working collectively to develop peace-integrated course modules, syllabi, and assessment mechanisms.

BARMM Development Partnerships

In June 2022, Chancellor Limbona led a delegation to the office of BARMM Chief Minister Ahod Ebrahim to present three strategic development proposals for the university: an Academic Center focused on Islamic Studies and Peace Education, an Eco-tourism Development project, and a Housing Project for faculty, staff, and students.<ref name="barmm"/>

The meeting signaled a growing alignment between the university's institutional ambitions and the BARMM government's priority of building Bangsamoro professionals.

In May 2024, she presided over the signing of a Memorandum of Agreement with the Ministry of Trade, Investments, and Tourism of BARMM (MTIT-BARMM) under the Rural Agro-Industrial Partnership for Inclusive Development (RAPID) Growth Project.

The MOA committed MSU-Maguindanao's ABM Department to providing business and advisory services to smallholder farmers in Maguindanao, particularly in the coconut, cacao, and coffee industries, connecting them with supplies, marketing channels, and training programs.

After the signing, Chancellor Limbona offered a remark that reflected both her faith and her sense of public duty: "Alhamdulillah for today, serbisyo para sa bayan."<ref name="rapid"/>

Climate Resilience and DOST Partnership

In 2024, MSU-Maguindanao signed a Memorandum of Agreement with the Technology Transfer and Promotion Division of the Department of Science and Technology's Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST-PCAARRD) for a climate resilience project in Datu Blah Sinsuat, Maguindanao.

The project focuses on rehabilitating 10 hectares of land using agroforestry techniques, establishing community nurseries, and training farmers on climate adaptation practices, directly responding to the devastation caused by Typhoon Paeng in October 2022.<ref name="dost"/>

Chancellor Limbona expressed the project's significance in terms of the university's contribution to the UN Sustainable Development Goals, particularly SDG 13 on Climate Action.

Digital Connectivity

In May 2023, MSU-Maguindanao and MSU-Tawi-Tawi College of Technology and Oceanography (MSU-TCTO) jointly received a digital connectivity project through the Development Academy of the Philippines (DAP), selected from 114 State Universities and Colleges across the country.

Chancellor Limbona framed the project's importance in terms that went beyond infrastructure: "The need and importance of digital connectivity is critical, and it will help in achieving the mandate of MSU-System to integrate the Muslims and the other cultural minorities into the mainstream of national life."

Women's Empowerment and Gender Equality

Chancellor Limbona signed a Memorandum of Understanding on the Diploma on Women, Peace and Security with Bangsamoro Women Commission (BWC) Chairperson Hadja Bainon G. Karon during the Culmination Program of the National Women's Month 2024, reaffirming her personal and institutional commitment to advancing women's

rights in the Bangsamoro region.

She has also participated in high-level international discussions on gender and security, including speaking at the 7th International Forum on Law and Religion on the subject of Institutional WPS Structures and Regional Networks.

Personal Values and Cultural Identity

Chancellor Limbona's leadership style is informed by a set of values that are deeply Bangsamoro in character: a sense of familial duty, a commitment to public service grounded in Islamic ethics, and an abiding awareness that the work of building institutions in conflict-affected communities is never finished.

Her frequent use of phrases like "Alhamdulillah" and "serbisyo para sa bayan" in public addresses reflects a personal approach to her role that integrates faith with civic obligation.

She comes from a family that has spent generations in public service and academic governance, and she carries that lineage not as a burden but as a framework for accountability.

Her support for the Women, Peace and Security agenda is not simply a programmatic choice. It reflects her understanding of what it means to grow up as a Bangsamoro woman, navigating expectations of tradition and the demands of modern institutional leadership simultaneously.

She has spoken in formal and international settings about the need to transform, not just mainstream, the WPS agenda in communities where women have historically been undervalued despite their central role in peacebuilding.

Recognition

Among the formal recognitions of her academic work, Chancellor Limbona received the Certificate of Academic Excellence from Cotabato City State Polytechnic College upon the completion of her doctoral degree in Public Administration.

MSU-Maguindanao's DWPS program, which she championed, has been internationally recognized as the first of its kind in Southeast Asia, and the university's role in hosting learning exchanges and building regional WPS networks has drawn formal acknowledgment from the United Nations, the British Government, and partner academic institutions in Indonesia and beyond.

She has been invited to deliver speeches and messages at national and international forums including the International Conference on Women, Peace and Security, the 7th International Forum on Law and Religion, and events organized by the UNDP Philippines.

Institutional Legacy

When historians of the Bangsamoro peace process look back at MSU-Maguindanao's arc from a modest agricultural college in Dinaig in 1973 to a globally engaged peace university in the 2020s, Chancellor Limbona's tenure will occupy a significant chapter.

She did not inherit an institution waiting to be globalized. She led a deliberate transformation, anchoring the university's research, extension, and academic programs to the realities of peacebuilding, gender justice, climate vulnerability, and rural development in Muslim Mindanao.

More than that, she demonstrated that a Bangsamoro woman, born and raised in Cotabato City, educated across Manila's major universities, rooted in a family of public servants, could lead an autonomous university into international prominence without losing sight of its most basic obligation: to give Bangsamoro students what they need to build decent lives.

Her phrase, "serbisyo para sa bayan," distilled in ordinary Tagalog, remains the most honest summary of what she has pursued across more than two decades in the same institution.

See Also

- Mindanao State University-Maguindanao
- Mindanao State University
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Women, Peace and Security
- Cotabato City
- Datu Odin Sinsuat, Maguindanao del Norte
- Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy
- United Nations Development Programme Philippines

Further Reading

- MSU-Maguindanao Official Website: https://msumaguindanao.edu.ph
- Office of the Chancellor, MSU-Maguindanao: https://msumaguindanao.edu.ph/office-of-the-chancellor/
- UNDP Philippines, Peace Integration Training at MSU: https://www.undp.org/philippines/news/mindanao-state-university-msu-institute-peace-and-development-mindanao-ipdm-and-undp-philippines-hold-effective-peace-integration
- UK Government, WPS Initiative in Philippines and Indonesia: https://www.gov.uk/government/news/uk-boosts-women-peace-and-security-in-philippines-and-indonesia
- PeaceGovPH, WPS Institutionalization in Higher Education: https://peace.gov.ph/2025/04/stakeholders-reaffirm-support-to-institutionalizing-the-wps-agenda-in-higher-education/
- BARMM Official Website, MSU-Maguindanao Development Plans: https://bangsamoro.gov.ph/news/latest-news/msu-mag-chancellor-chief-minister-discuss-proposed-devt-plans-partnership/

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